

Interested or interesting?

Learner workbook

Describe a feeling and what causes it.

Understand the distinction

For many pairs, the -ed adjective describes a feeling: bored, excited, interested. The -ing adjective describes what causes that feeling: boring, exciting, interesting.

People can cause feelings too. A person can be interesting, and a story can be exciting. Choose by meaning, not by whether the noun is a person or a thing. After interested in, use a noun or an -ing verb.

Compare the patterns

FEELING

I am interested in photography.

This describes my feeling.

CAUSE

The photographer is interesting.

This person attracts my interest.

ACTIVITY

I am interested in learning more.

Use learning after in.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. The long wait made me feel ____ . (bored / boring)

2. Can a person be interesting?

3. Correct this: I am interested in learn Spanish.

Use it in your own life

Describe an activity and how you feel about it.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. bored

Describe the feeling of the person waiting.

2. Yes. A person can cause interest.

The distinction is feeling versus cause, not person versus thing.

3. I am interested in learning Spanish.

A verb after this preposition uses the -ing form.

One possible response

The class is challenging, but I feel excited about learning.

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-03.html